Easter Bunny

Stuart King gets ready for Easter with this lovely toy

Some believe that the Anglo-Saxon Goddess of Spring, Eostre, had a hare as her companion. This hare symbolises fertility and rebirth; the beginning of spring. Her presence was felt in the flowering of plants and the birth of babies, both animal and human. Eggs are symbols of fertility.

Christians later changed the symbol of the hare to a rabbit, which has become the Easter Bunny. From a Christian perspective, Easter eggs are said to represent Jesus' emergence from the tomb and resurrection, again symbolising a new beginning.

The decoration of eggs is believed to date back to at least the 13th century. In some communities, eggs laid in the week before Easter were collected and decorated, before being hidden by the Easter Bunny on Easter Sunday, to be searched for by excited children.

As this project is very much a fun one aimed at children, you must be aware that any applied finish must be child friendly, see www.toysadvice.co.uk/toy-safety-standards-uk.html.

I anticipate that the egg will wobble; the bottom section will definitely do so. Keep the upper portion as light as possible to increase this effect. My inspiration for this project is the tiny (5mm high), turned German eggs from the 19th century. These contained a tiny carved doll, which was sold as the 'smallest doll in the world'.

I will take you through most of the main sequences but I must point out that I assume a certain amount of woodturning competence. I would encourage you to use your creative imagination, employing my images and drawings as a starting point. Any measurements are there as a guide only and can be varied to suit. For the egg I decided to use oak (*Quercus robur*) so that the obvious grain runs through the complete piece; this will please those of you that prefer a 'real wood' finish. As we mostly think of Easter eggs being decorated, usually painted, a light coloured, fine grained timber such as sycamore (*Acer pesudoplatanus*) would be ideal for this. Getting the 'egg profile' right is not easy: it is a good exercise in form. I do not pretend that mine is perfect!

PHOTOGRAPHS BY STUART KING

STUART KING

Stuart has spent a lifetime researching, recording and collecting anything about the rural past and today is a well-known artist craftsman, demonstrator, international lecturer and photo-journalist. He still actively records traditional crafts, and history via photography and video.

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